

LIBERTY CYBER THREAT INTELLIGENCE

THE ALAMO THREAT BRIEF™

OPEN SOURCE INTELLIGENCE

ISSUE	ATB-2026-11
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DOMINANT JUDGMENT	IRAN’S CYBER CAMPAIGN IS WARTIME OPERATIONS

Executive decision intelligence for Texas critical infrastructure.

Coverage: 18–24 May 2026 — Dominant Theme: Iran’s Cyber Campaign Is Wartime Operations, Not Background Noise. This week’s brief is anchored by a structural escalation in Iran’s wartime cyber posture. New Unit 42 research confirmed active Iranian espionage targeting aviation and oil and gas sector software engineers — adding operational specificity to the advisory framework established by CISA AA26-097a, which documented confirmed PLC disruption across energy, water, and government infrastructure since March 2026. That advisory re-enters this issue not as new reporting but as escalation context: what was a warning in April is now confirmed active campaign behavior in May. Simultaneously, the convergence of Iran war oil shocks and AI-driven electricity demand is compressing Texas’s energy operating environment in ways that have no precedent in any prior threat cycle. The decision facing Texas executives this week is not whether these threats are real — they are confirmed. The decision is whether leadership has reframed OT governance, vendor access, and energy continuity as wartime strategic resilience issues.

Board Implications This Week — Ask

Which OT systems, building management devices, or internet-facing field equipment in your environment match the Rockwell Automation/Allen-Bradley or ATG device profiles confirmed in CISA AA26-097a? This is not an IT question. It is a board continuity question. If the answer is not known within 48 hours, the gap is governance — not technology.

Board Implications This Week — Direct

Require written confirmation from operations leadership this week that no PLC, ATG, or OT device in your environment is directly internet-exposed without authentication. If that confirmation cannot be provided, treat it as an open governance risk and document that the board was informed.

Board Implications This Week — Document

Record the board’s awareness of the active Iranian wartime cyber campaign against U.S. energy and aviation infrastructure, and the specific steps leadership directed in response. If a cyber event affecting your sector occurs in the next 90 days, the record of informed oversight will matter more than the technical response log.

Board Implications This Week — Rehearse

Run one integrated scenario before peak summer grid demand: Iranian-linked OT disruption combined with ERCOT stress and degraded vendor support. These are not independent failure modes. They are the same event

arriving through different doors simultaneously.

CENTERPIECE ANALYSIS

The dominant analytic call this week is that Iran has operationalized cyber as its primary asymmetric instrument against the U.S. homeland — and the campaign is active, multi-vector, and confirmed. Unit 42's May 22 reporting documents Iranian operatives using AI-generated job postings and malware-infected video conferencing software to target software engineers at U.S. aviation and oil and gas firms. That reporting is new this week. What gives it strategic weight is the operational context behind it: the same Iranian APT cluster — CyberAv3ngers, also tracked as Shahid Kaveh Group, Storm-0784, and UNC5691, operating under IRGC-CEC — has been disrupting Rockwell Automation/Allen-Bradley PLCs across U.S. energy, water, and government infrastructure since at least March 2026, per CISA AA26-097a. The May 22 reporting confirms this actor is still active, still expanding its target set, and now using AI-assisted social engineering to gain human capital access inside critical sector organizations.

The strategic logic is not complicated. Iran cannot reach the U.S. homeland with missiles or drones. Cyber is therefore not a supplementary capability — it is the primary instrument of retaliation, intelligence collection, and coercive signaling during an active war. Tehran's assessed objectives are: collecting intelligence on U.S. energy market positioning and military logistics, pre-positioning against infrastructure with disruptive value, and signaling deterrence capability to constrain U.S. and Israeli decision-making. The campaign's tempo — confirmed PLC disruption in March, ATG breaches in May, aviation and oil sector human capital targeting in May — is consistent with a deliberate escalation ladder, not opportunistic activity.

Bottom line: Texas is not a peripheral exposure in this campaign. It is a direct one. The state is simultaneously a top oil and gas producer, a leading LNG exporter, a rapidly expanding AI infrastructure hub, and an ERCOT-dependent power market under compounding AI-driven demand pressure. ATB-2026-10 flagged Iranian OT targeting as a sustained background indicator. This week's reporting escalates that assessment to confirmed active campaign behavior. I&W 5 from ATB-2026-10 has been confirmed.

Section I

Key Judgments

KJ-1

Liberty CTI assesses it is **highly likely** (>80%) that Iran's wartime cyber campaign is in an active, multi-vector operational phase — not a pre-positioning or background intelligence collection phase. The combination of confirmed PLC disruption (CISA AA26-097a, March–April 2026), suspected ATG infrastructure access (May 2026), and active human capital targeting of aviation and oil and gas software engineers (Unit 42, May 22, 2026) constitutes an escalating operational pattern, not isolated incidents. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: Unit 42 May 22, 2026 (new this week); CISA AA26-097a April 7, 2026 (re-entered as escalation context); CNN/Lyngaas May 15, 2026 (ATG breach reporting). New this week: Unit 42 confirmation of AI-assisted social engineering in active campaign execution, directly escalating ATB-2026-10 I&W 5 from Sustained to Rising. Primary uncertainty: whether current operations reflect the ceiling of Iran's intended disruption threshold, or whether geopolitical escalation would push the campaign toward active infrastructure

disruption.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Texas energy, aviation, and OT-dependent organizations should treat this as a current operational warning. The question is not whether to prepare — it is whether preparation is already complete.

KJ-2

Liberty CTI assesses it is **likely** (55–80%) that the convergence of Iran war energy price shocks and AI-driven electricity demand has created a dual-vector energy stress environment that adversaries can exploit and that Texas governance structures are not currently calibrated to manage simultaneously.

MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: Axios/Harder May 14, 2026 (energy costs up 18% YoY; NERC Level 3 alert); ERCOT load forecast data; Liberty CTI Weekly Watch Note Rollup May 17–23, 2026. Builds on ATB-2026-10 ERCOT demand reporting; new this week is the NERC Level 3 warning designation and the explicit geopolitical convergence between Iran war oil pricing and AI power demand stress. Primary uncertainty: timing and magnitude of summer 2026 peak demand realization; actual Iranian willingness to transition from intelligence collection to disruptive energy infrastructure operations.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Energy executives and ERCOT-connected critical infrastructure operators must integrate geopolitical threat scenario planning with physical grid continuity planning. These are no longer separate problems.

KJ-3

Liberty CTI assesses it is **likely** (55–80%) that AI-enabled adversary operations have outpaced the identity and access governance frameworks most Texas enterprises currently operate under — creating a category of cyber risk that does not fit inside conventional IT security models and is already being operationalized against U.S. organizations. MODERATE CONFIDENCE

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: CFR/Nguyen May 18, 2026 (CrowdStrike documents 89% YoY increase in AI-enabled adversary operations; Anthropic disclosure of Chinese state actor use of Claude to automate espionage against 30+ organizations). New this week: CFR analysis and CrowdStrike data published after ATB-2026-10 coverage window. Primary uncertainty: rate of enterprise adoption of AI agent governance controls; whether current identity management tools can detect nonhuman identity misuse at adversary operational tempo.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: CISOs and risk committees should add AI agent governance and nonhuman identity risk to the Q2/Q3 board agenda. This is a current gap adversaries have already confirmed they are exploiting — not a future-state risk.

Section II

What Changed This Week

Unit 42 — Iran Targeting Aviation and Oil & Gas Software Engineers NEW — 22 May 2026

Palo Alto Networks Unit 42 published research this week confirming Iranian operatives used AI-generated fake job postings and malware-laced video conferencing software to target software engineers at U.S. aviation and oil and gas firms, as well as organizations in Israel and the UAE. In at least one case, operatives impersonated a U.S. airline advertising for a senior software engineer — a posting Unit 42

assessed was AI-written. Unit 42 confirmed no breach of oil, gas, or aviation firms based on their data, but confirmed other targets in the global campaign were breached and declined to identify them. The Iranian group is assessed as showing no signs of deceleration. This is new this week and directly actionable for Texas energy and aviation-adjacent organizations.

CISA AA26-097A — PLC Disruption Confirmed Across U.S. Critical Infrastructure ESCALATION CONTEXT — Advisory April 7, 2026 / Escalated by Unit 42 May 22

CISA Advisory AA26-097a was issued April 7, 2026, outside this ATB's collection window, and is not carried as new reporting. It re-enters this week as confirmed escalation context for the Unit 42 findings. The advisory — issued jointly by FBI, CISA, NSA, EPA, DOE, and U.S. Cyber Command — confirmed that the Iranian APT cluster (CyberAv3ngers / IRGC-CEC, also tracked as Shahid Kaveh Group, Storm-0784, UNC5691) disrupted Rockwell Automation/Allen-Bradley PLCs across U.S. energy, water, and government infrastructure since at least March 2026. Confirmed operational impact included extraction of PLC project files containing ladder logic, falsification of HMI/SCADA display values, and financial losses to victim organizations. Censys data identified 5,219 internet-exposed Rockwell/Allen-Bradley hosts globally; 74.6% are in the United States — with a disproportionate share on cellular carrier networks indicative of field-deployed devices on cellular modems. The Unit 42 reporting this week confirms the same actor cluster has expanded targeting beyond OT infrastructure into human capital compromise inside aviation and commercial energy organizations. The delta from ATB-2026-10: that issue flagged Iranian OT targeting as a single background line with no specific source and I&W 5 as Sustained. This week's reporting escalates that indicator to Rising with primary-source confirmation.

Iranian Suspected ATG Breach at U.S. Gas Stations ESCALATION — 15 May 2026 / Not covered in ATB-2026-10

CNN reported May 15 that Iranian actors are the leading suspect in breaches of automatic tank gauge (ATG) systems at U.S. gas stations — devices that have been internet-exposed without password protection since at least 2015, with over 5,800 exposed units documented by researchers at that time. In some cases, hackers tampered with display readings. No federal directive mandating ATG password protocols currently exists, though CISA has flagged ATG exposure in multiple prior advisories. This reporting falls within ATB-2026-10's collection window but was not included in that issue. It enters ATB-2026-11 as escalation confirmation of the Iran OT targeting pattern and further evidence of the multi-vector campaign structure.

NERC Level 3 Alert — AI Data Center Demand May Strain U.S. Grid NEW ESCALATION — Week of 14 May 2026

NERC issued its highest-level warning that exploding AI data center power demand could strain U.S. electricity systems — a designation with no recent precedent. Combined with energy costs up 18% year-over-year from Iran war oil shocks, this establishes a dual-vector energy stress environment with direct ERCOT implications for Texas. Builds on ATB-2026-10 ERCOT demand reporting. The new element this week is the NERC Level 3 designation itself and its explicit convergence with wartime energy pricing, confirming the energy stress environment is not a single-variable planning problem.

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

Convergence Assessment: The ATG breach and the Unit 42 aviation and oil sector targeting are not separate events. They are two data points in one campaign. Iran is using every available access vector — human capital compromise, internet-exposed OT, and unauthenticated field devices — to build leverage against U.S. energy and logistics infrastructure during an active war. Treat them as a single operational picture, not a list of incidents.

Section III

Cross-Sector Implications — Texas Operating Environment

Energy ERCOT / OT / LNG / Grid	What changed: Iranian actors confirmed targeting oil and gas firms for intelligence on market positioning. Energy costs up 18% YoY from Iran war oil dynamics. NERC Level 3 alert confirms AI data center power demand is straining grid systems. Why it matters locally: Texas is the only state simultaneously a top oil and gas producer, a leading LNG exporter, a major AI infrastructure hub, and an ERCOT-isolated power market. The OT exposure is direct: 74.6% of 5,219 globally-exposed Rockwell/Allen-Bradley PLC hosts are in the United States. Decision this creates: Energy executives must determine whether OT security governance is calibrated for wartime adversary posture, not only compliance cycles. The question is not whether your organization is a target. The question is whether your OT governance assumed peacetime.
Financial Inflation / Exposure / Recovery	What changed: Oil-driven CPI at 3.8% in April 2026 is constraining policy flexibility precisely as adversary targeting of energy and aviation infrastructure increases. Why it matters locally: Texas financial institutions with credit exposure to energy sector clients, LNG operators, or logistics-dependent industries face compounded risk: geopolitical commodity volatility and active adversary targeting of the underlying infrastructure are occurring on the same timeline. Decision this creates: Risk models that treat cyber and commodity volatility as independent variables are misframed. Nation-state actors as drivers of sector-wide operational disruption do not wait for a security incident report before affecting the balance sheet.

AI / DIB /
Healthcare
Governance /
Identity / OT

What changed: CFR documented a 89% YoY increase in AI-enabled adversary operations. Anthropic confirmed Chinese state actors ran an automated espionage campaign — with AI performing 80–90% of the operational work — against roughly 30 organizations. Nonhuman identities now substantially outnumber human users in enterprise environments.

Why it matters locally: Texas AI infrastructure and DIB organizations face AI-assisted campaigns that move faster than human detection cycles. Healthcare organizations should treat CISA AA26-097a as directly applicable — PLCs and building management OT are widely deployed in hospital infrastructure and among the least-governed technology assets in the sector.

Decision this creates: AI agent governance and nonhuman identity management belong on the Q2/Q3 board agenda. The governance gap adversaries have already confirmed they are exploiting is not a future risk — it is a current exposure.

Section IV

Indicators & Warnings — PIR Watch, 1 to 4 Weeks

PIR 1–4 / IND 1 Iranian Escalation Threshold Signal [↑ Rising]

- Watch for any confirmed Iranian strike on Strait of Hormuz maritime infrastructure, undersea internet cables, or commercial U.S. energy OT systems beyond current intelligence collection and ATG tampering.
- Would indicate a shift from pre-positioning and intelligence collection to active disruption — requiring immediate escalation of executive continuity posture and activation of OT incident response plans.
- Tied to: PIR 1 (adversary intent), PIR 3 (geopolitical triggers), PIR 4 (business impact).

PIR 1–2 / IND 2 CISA Follow-On Advisory Naming Commercial Energy or LNG Targets [↑ Rising]

- Watch for a second joint advisory (FBI/CISA/NSA/DOE/CNMF) expanding AA26-097a to name commercial energy, LNG, or petrochemical operators — or an update with new indicators of compromise.
- Would confirm the campaign has expanded beyond water and government sectors into commercial energy infrastructure with direct Texas exposure.
- Tied to: PIR 1 (adversary intent), PIR 2 (geopolitical triggers for cyber escalation).

PIR 1–4–5 / IND 3 Confirmed Breach of Oil, Gas, or Aviation Firm [↑ Rising]

- Unit 42 currently reports no confirmed breach of oil, gas, or aviation firms in this campaign. A confirmed public disclosure would move this from pre-positioning to active exploitation.
- Would fundamentally change the risk calculus for Texas energy sector executives and their boards — shifting governance posture from preparation to crisis response.
- Tied to: PIR 1, PIR 4, PIR 5 (business impact, disclosure and escalation thresholds).

PIR 2–6 / IND 4 ERCOT Emergency Declaration During Summer Peak [↑ Rising]

- Watch for any Texas grid emergency declaration, particularly during peak summer demand as AI data center load growth tests the NERC Level 3 warning threshold.
- Would validate the energy-adversary convergence thesis and trigger cascading exposure across finance, healthcare, and logistics simultaneously — creating the multi-sector disruption scenario adversaries do not need to engineer if the grid delivers it independently.
- Tied to: PIR 2 (geopolitical triggers), PIR 6 (executive decision readiness).

PIR 3–7 / IND 5 Federal Election-Cycle Cyber Warning from DHS or FBI [→ Sustained]

- Former CISA Director Chris Krebs assessed this week that Iran is unlikely to sit out the midterm cycle given its 2020 and 2024 election interference track record. No dedicated federal team is currently activated to counter foreign digital threats to elections.
- Any DHS or FBI advisory on Iranian election-related cyber activity would indicate the wartime cyber campaign is expanding beyond infrastructure into political and institutional destabilization — with direct implications for Texas political and financial institutions.
- Tied to: PIR 3 (third-party exposure), PIR 7 (decision readiness and escalation authority).

Section V

Governance Implication Block

Decision at risk	Whether Texas executive leadership has reframed OT governance, vendor remote access, telecom continuity, and energy dependency as wartime strategic resilience issues — or continues treating them as IT-level problems that do not require board attention or documented oversight.
Owner	Board Risk Committee / CEO / COO / CISO / General Counsel / OT Operations Leadership. CFO ownership is required where energy pricing volatility, vendor payment continuity, or insurance recovery timing affects restoration capacity.
Consequence of delay	Organizations that discover OT exposure, ATG vulnerabilities, vendor access gaps, or energy continuity weaknesses during an active Iranian cyber campaign will have no decision window. The cost of inaction is a board-level event during active adversary operations. The cost of action this week is a governance conversation.
Action this week	Confirm whether Rockwell Automation/Allen-Bradley or Siemens PLCs in your environment are internet-facing and cross-reference against CISA AA26-097a. Validate ATG systems and building management OT are not directly internet-exposed. Review software engineer onboarding and external job-posting verification processes against Iranian-style AI-assisted recruitment tradecraft. Brief the board or risk committee on wartime adversary posture before the next scheduled meeting — do not wait for the quarterly cycle.
Record to preserve	Board and risk committee briefing records reflecting awareness of the Iranian wartime campaign; OT asset inventories and internet-exposure review documentation; vendor remote access approvals and review dates; continuity plan records; CISA advisory acknowledgment and organizational response; escalation authority documentation.

From Warning to Decision

Test what this means for your organization.

Reading the warning is one thing. Knowing whether your leadership would recognize it, decide in time, and document the call is another. Liberty CTI starts by establishing your decision environment, then tests it under pressure.

EXECUTIVE INTELLIGENCE BASELINE + EXECUTIVE DECISION EXERCISE →

Section VI

Prior Judgment Tracker

Prior judgment	ATB-2026-10 I&W 5 assessed Iranian OT targeting as a <i>Sustained</i> background indicator tied to Middle East escalation. No specific primary source was cited; no operational confirmation was available in that collection window.
Current status	Escalated to Rising. Unit 42 May 22 reporting and ATG breach reporting confirm the indicator has moved from background to active campaign behavior with primary-source attribution.
What changed	Unit 42 provided operational specificity: actor identity (CyberAv3ngers / IRGC-CEC), target sectors (aviation, oil & gas), tradecraft (AI-generated job postings, malware-infected meeting software), and confirmed activity in the same campaign cluster as CISA AA26-097a. ATB-2026-10 had the right signal. ATB-2026-11 has the confirmation.
Confidence movement	KJ-1 confidence rated HIGH. Prior moderate background assessment confirmed by independent primary-source reporting within one collection window.
Next indicator	A confirmed breach of a U.S. oil, gas, or aviation firm; a CISA follow-on advisory expanding AA26-097a to commercial energy; an ERCOT emergency declaration; or a Strait of Hormuz escalation event would raise posture to HIGH / IMMINENT and require immediate executive action.

Section VII — Sourcing

Open Source Basis

PRIMARY SOURCES — ATB-2026-11 — COVERAGE WEEK 18–24 MAY 2026

GOVERNMENT / REGULATORY

CISA / FBI / NSA / EPA / DOE / CNMF — Advisory AA26-097A: Iranian-Affiliated Cyber Actors Exploit PLCs Across U.S. Critical Infrastructure

cisa.gov/news-events/cybersecurity-advisories/aa26-097a

Published April 7, 2026. Re-entered this issue as escalation context for Unit 42 May 22 reporting. Not counted as new-week reporting. Basis for KJ-1, Section II, and Governance Implication Block.

GRID / REGULATORY

NERC — Level 3 Reliability Alert: Large Load Challenges from AI Data Center Growth

nerc.com/newsroom/nerc-issues-level-3-alert-reliability-guideline-focused-on-large-load-challenges

Published week of May 14, 2026. Basis for KJ-2 and Energy sector implication. New this week.

GOVERNMENT / REGULATORY

NSA / CISA / FBI — Joint Guidance: Counter China State-Sponsored Actors Targeting Critical Infrastructure

[nsa.gov — NSA/CISA/FBI Joint Guidance](https://nsa.gov/NSA/CISA/FBI_Joint_Guidance)

Basis for federal degraded-service planning posture assessment in Section II and Governance Block.

THREAT INTELLIGENCE

Palo Alto Networks Unit 42 — Iran-Nexus Espionage Campaign Targeting Aviation, Oil & Gas

unit42.paloaltonetworks.com

Published May 22, 2026. Primary source for KJ-1, Section II lead item, and actor attribution. New this week.

WIRE / U.S. OFFICIAL SOURCING

CNN / Sean Lyngaas — ATG Gas Station Breach (15 May); Aviation & Oil Targeting (22 May)

[CNN May 15, 2026 — ATG Breach](#)

Cited for confirmed U.S. official characterization and institutional response quotes only. Primary intelligence: Unit 42 and CISA AA26-097a.

GEOPOLITICAL / SECTOR ANALYSIS

CFR / Vinh Nguyen — Scaling Intelligence: The Security Foundations Beneath America's AI Ambitions Are Cracking

[cfr.org — Scaling Intelligence, May 18, 2026](#)

Cited for CrowdStrike 89% YoY figure and Anthropic disclosure of Chinese state actor AI use. Basis for KJ-3 and AI/DIB implication.

ENERGY / SECTOR ANALYSIS

Axios / Amy Harder — The Energy Squeeze Behind the Iran War and AI Boom

[axios.com — Energy Squeeze, May 14, 2026](#)

Cited for 18% YoY energy cost increase, NERC Level 3 context, and CPI convergence framing. Basis for KJ-2 and Energy implication.

INTERNAL

Liberty CTI — Weekly Watch Note Rollup, 17–23 May 2026

[libertycti.com](#)

Internal collection document. Basis for PIR movement tracking, adversary geopolitical framing, and cascade assessment.

TORCH FUSION CYCLE

WHAT: The week of 18–24 May 2026 was defined by operational confirmation of a threat that had been assessed but not yet sourced. Unit 42's May 22 reporting confirmed that the Iranian APT cluster behind CISA AA26-097a is active, expanding, and using AI-assisted social engineering to penetrate aviation and oil and gas sector human capital. The NERC Level 3 alert confirmed that AI-driven power demand stress has reached a threshold requiring formal regulatory warning. ATB-2026-10's I&W 5 has been confirmed. **WHO:** Iran-affiliated IRGC-CEC / CyberAv3ngers is the dominant adversary this week across OT, aviation, and commercial energy targeting. China remains the pacing long-term strategic threat through pre-positioning and nonhuman identity exploitation. Russia's wartime infrastructure pressure continues increasing hybrid retaliation incentives. **WHY:** Iran lacks kinetic reach against the U.S. homeland. Cyber is its primary asymmetric instrument. The campaign's multi-vector structure — PLC disruption, ATG tampering, human capital compromise via AI-assisted social engineering — is consistent with deliberate escalation ladder behavior, not opportunistic activity. Texas is a direct target environment, not a peripheral one. **WHAT NEXT:** Leadership should treat OT exposure, vendor access governance, and energy continuity as a single wartime resilience problem, not three separate technical workstreams. The voluntary preparation window is narrowing. The cost of inaction is a board-level event during active adversary operations. *Warnings that arrive too late are not warnings. They are after-action reports.*

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